



THIS SONG OF THE MAN AND HIS WIFE IS OF NO PLACE AND EVERY PLACE

SUNRISE / 1927

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Silent drama

DIRECTOR

F. W. Murnau

WRITERS

**Carl Mayer (screenplay);
Hermann Sudermann
(short story)**

STARS

**George O'Brien, Janet
Gaynor, Margaret
Livingston, Bodil Rosing**

BEFORE

1922 Murnau's *Nosferatu* helps to define the horror genre in a nightmarish version of *Dracula*.

AFTER

1927 *Metropolis*, Fritz Lang's science-fiction classic, also features the spectacle of the modern city.

1930 Murnau's *City Girl* tells the story of a flapper falling in love with a farm boy and being rejected by his family.

In 1927, one movie changed the course of cinema history: *The Jazz Singer*, starring Al Jolson, was the first ever feature-length "talkie." But another song was playing in picture palaces that year, and it was a silent movie. In *Sunrise: A Song of Two Humans*, German director F. W. Murnau attempted to distill a universal human experience into 90 wordless minutes of beautiful monochrome imagery, accompanied only by music and sound effects.

At a lakeside village, two clandestine lovers meet under the moonlight. The man (George O'Brien) is an honest country

fellow who has been seduced by the vampish woman from the city (Margaret Livingston). She urges him to sell his farm and come with her to pursue a life of excitement in the city. The man is married, however, to his sweet young wife (Janet Gaynor). When he asks the woman: "And my wife?" a sly look comes into his lover's eyes. "Couldn't she get drowned?" is the chilling title card.

The rural setting, creeping fog, and shifting, spidery shadows of this scene recall Murnau's other great masterpiece, the archetypal vampire movie *Nosferatu*. *Sunrise* looks set to deliver an equally



F. W. Murnau Director

Born in Germany in 1888, Friedrich Wilhelm Murnau fought for his

country in the horror of World War I before making a horror of his own: *Nosferatu*, the first movie to be based on *Dracula*. *The Last Laugh* proved that Murnau could move his audiences as skillfully as he could terrify them. A highly

literate man, Murnau brought Goethe's *Faust* to the big screen before moving to Hollywood in 1926. His first US movie was *Sunrise: A Song of Two Humans*. He died in a car crash in 1931.

Key movies

1922 *Nosferatu*
1924 *The Last Laugh*
1927 *Sunrise*